

Macbeth Anchor Worksheet

WEEK 1: PROPHECY IS NOT PROOF

Purpose: This worksheet asks you to use the paired *Macbeth Lit-Anchor Reading* to test Macbeth's reasoning with Whately's four questions: conclusion, stated reason, hidden assumption, and whether the conclusion follows. Use evidence from both Macbeth passages. Your answers should analyze reasoning, not simply retell the plot.

Part 1: Prophecy and Inference

Part 1 Q1: In Act 1, Scene 3, what exactly do the witches tell Macbeth, and what do they **not** tell him? Explain the difference between a prediction and a command.

Part 1 Q1 ANSWER BOX

Part 1 Q2: Macbeth treats the two confirmed titles as “happy prologues” to kingship. Use Whately's four-part test to analyze Macbeth's reasoning: identify the conclusion, stated reason, hidden assumption, and whether the conclusion follows.

Part 1 Q2 ANSWER BOX

Part 2: Banquo's Warning

Part 2 Q1: Why is Banquo's question, "What, can the devil speak true?" logically important? Explain how Banquo gives Macbeth a rival interpretation of the prophecy.

Part 2 Q1 ANSWER BOX

Part 2 Q2: Explain this Week 1 claim in your own words: **prediction is not permission; possibility is not command; desire is not proof.** Use one moment from Act 1, Scene 3 as evidence.

Part 2 Q2 ANSWER BOX

Part 3: Macbeth Weighs Reasons

Part 3 Q1: In Act 1, Scene 7, what conclusion does Macbeth's soliloquy seem to support? List at least three reasons Macbeth gives against murdering Duncan.

Part 3 Q1 ANSWER BOX

Part 3 Q2: Macbeth says he has “no spur” except “vaulting ambition.” Is ambition a reason, a desire, or both? Explain why ambition alone does or does not prove that Macbeth should act.

Part 3 Q2 ANSWER BOX

Part 3: Macbeth Weighs Reasons, Continued

Part 3 Q3: Test this argument: “Macbeth should not murder Duncan.” Use Macbeth’s reasons from Act 1, Scene 7 and explain whether the conclusion follows.

Part 3 Q3 ANSWER BOX

Part 4: Anchor Synthesis

Part 4 Q1: Choose one claim below, then complete a four-part Macbeth argument skeleton. Your answer must include **Claim/conclusion**, **Stated reason**, **Hidden assumption**, and **Follows**.

- The prophecy proves Macbeth will be king.
- If Macbeth is destined to be king, he is not responsible for what he does.
- Macbeth should not kill Duncan.
- Ambition is Macbeth’s only real reason for murder.

Part 4 Q1 ANSWER BOX

Part 4: Anchor Synthesis, Continued

Part 4 Q2: Write one strong paragraph answering this question: What does Macbeth show about Whately's claim that logic can discipline reasoning but cannot replace virtue? Use at least one specific moment from the reading.

Part 4 Q2 ANSWER BOX